

4

EXPERIMENT

I come across many startups that are struggling to answer the following questions: Which customer opinions should we listen to, if any? How should we prioritize across the many features we could build? Which features are essential to the product's success and which are ancillary? What can be changed safely, and what might anger customers? What might please today's customers at the expense of tomorrow's? What should we work on next?

These are some of the questions teams struggle to answer if they have followed the “let's just ship a product and see what happens” plan. I call this the “just do it” school of entrepreneurship after Nike's famous slogan.¹ Unfortunately, if the plan is to see what happens, a team is guaranteed to succeed—at seeing what happens—but won't necessarily gain validated learning. This is one of the most important lessons of the scientific method: if you cannot fail, you cannot learn.

FROM ALCHEMY TO SCIENCE

The Lean Startup methodology reconceives a startup's efforts as experiments that test its strategy to see which parts are brilliant and which are crazy. A true experiment follows the scientific method. It begins with a clear hypothesis that makes predictions about what is supposed to happen. It then tests those predictions empirically. Just as scientific experimentation is informed by theory, startup experimentation is guided by the startup's vision. The goal of every